

MINDSET

The New Psychology of Success

CAROL S. DWECK, PH.D

The Big “So What”



Your mindset—how you see yourself—shapes how you respond to people and events, to affect your outcomes. In this book, Dweck draws on 20 years of research to explain how you can recognize, understand and change a fundamental mindset to impact all aspects of your life.

Growth vs Fixed Mindset



The Power of Mindsets



Why do some people fall apart in face of setbacks, while others turn their failures into success? Why are some people obsessed about proving themselves, while others can laugh at and learn from their mistakes? The key difference is in their mindset.



Dweck found that there's a fundamental difference in mindset—**growth vs fixed mindset**—that explains many success factors, such as resilience, self-belief, and the willingness to take risks and strive for excellence.

- The fixed mindset is the belief that your qualities *cannot* be changed. Since you believe these qualities are a permanent part of who you are, you feel the need to constantly prove yourself.
- The growth mindset is the belief that your qualities *can* be changed and nurtured through effort. You believe that people may be born with different gifts, interests, or

KEY QUOTES

“Changing people’s beliefs—even the simplest beliefs—can have profound effects.”

“The passion for stretching yourself and sticking to it, even (or especially) when it’s not going well, is the hallmark of the growth mindset.”

temperaments, but everyone can change and grow through experience and practice.



Indeed, mindsets aren't permanent and can be changed, i.e. you can choose what you believe. You're likely to have a mix of both mindsets, but skew toward one of them. You also don't have the same mindset all the time. For example, you may have a fixed mindset toward your personality but a growth mindset toward your abilities.

Mindset → Definition & Approach to Success



Learning vs Validation:

- People with a fixed mindset define success as being perfect, mistake-free, smart or right. The focus is on validating themselves. However, those with a growth mindset believe they are successful so long as they're improving. This frees them to focus on growth.
- As babies, we weren't afraid to fail or make mistakes. However, as we grow older, we start to worry about how others think of us; we want to appear smart and successful, and avoid situations where we look bad. Returning to a growth mindset means refocusing on stretching ourselves to become smarter and better, rather than just appearing to be so.



Stretching vs Certainty:

- People with growth mindsets thrive when they embrace challenges. They seek to learn from others who are better than them or can push/help them to grow. They love experiences that stretch them, and are driven by a desire to push their boundaries—so much so that they sometimes achieve the impossible.
- On the other hand, people with a fixed mindset thrive when they are in their comfort zone, and feel certain of their success. They're interested only when they see results, and lose interest when things don't work out predictably. Hence, they tend to surround themselves with people who make them feel/look good, and prefer tried-and-tested activities that validate what they're confident or good at.

KEY QUOTES

"Mindsets are just beliefs. They're powerful beliefs, but they're just something in your mind, and you can change your mind."

"It's not about immediate perfection. It's about learning something over time: confronting a challenge and making progress."

"If you're somebody when you're successful, what are you when you're unsuccessful?"

"People in a growth mindset don't just seek challenge, they thrive on it. The bigger the challenge, the more they stretch."



Ability vs Learning. Your potential depends on your ability to develop new skills, and cannot be measured by a test.

- Unfortunately, people with fixed mindsets allow themselves to be limited by test scores and evaluations that supposedly tell them what they can achieve. Or, they may use tests and success symbols to prove that they are special.
- Those with growth mindsets know that they're only limited by their willingness and ability to learn. They constantly seek out opportunities to grow and stretch themselves. That's why many ordinary or even underperforming kids can grow up to become outstanding artists, sportspeople or scientists.



Identifying & developing potential. There's nothing wrong with having self-confidence and belief. The danger comes when you feel you're entitled to success because you're special, or when you define your self-worth by your achievements. When you do so, you'll start to fear losing this sense of specialness.

- Marina Semyonova (a renowned Russian dancer and teacher) identified potential and selected her students by observing how they handled feedback during their trial period.
- NASA prefers candidates who have bounced back from massive failure, over those who have a track record of only successes.



Those with a growth mindset generally have a more accurate self-assessment of their strengths and limitations. Since they believe they can improve in any area, they focus less on inflating their abilities to feed their ego. Instead, they more objectively assess their current abilities so they can identify exactly what/how to improve.

Mindset → Definition & Approach to Failure



When things go wrong, everyone feels bad to some degree. The difference is in how we respond.

- People with a fixed mindset allow the failure to define them permanently ("I'm a failure"). They may blame themselves, throw up their hands and decide there's nothing they can

KEY QUOTES

"An assessment at one point in time has little value for understanding someone's ability, let alone their potential to succeed in the future."

"The fixed mindset does not allow people the luxury of becoming. They have to already be."

"There (are) two meanings to ability, not one: a fixed ability that needs to be proven, and a changeable ability that can be developed through learning."

do. Or, they may try to protect their image by hiding their deficiencies, finding blame or excuses. Since they believe their abilities are fixed and nothing helps, they're more likely to give up or get depressed.

- Those with a growth mindset may also feel upset, but they see the mistake as an incident and a problem to be overcome ("I failed this time"). They try to identify their shortfalls, confront the challenges, and seek alternative routes to success.

 If you deny your mistakes, you can't learn from them. In a study, college students with growth mindsets took reference from (and learned from) other students who did better than them. Students with fixed mindsets tried to make themselves feel better by looking at others who fared worse than them, and/or find excuses.

 Negative labels and stereotypes affect everyone, but are especially damaging to people with fixed mindsets.

- Women with fixed mindsets (and are aware of the stereotype that "women are bad at math and science") tend to perform worse than their male counterparts. They also tend to drop out of math and science as they feel they don't belong.
- Those with growth mindsets tend to be less affected by negative labels and stereotypes, as they see them more objectively and they believe they can overcome any disadvantages.

Mindset → Attitude Toward Effort



Talent vs Effort:

- Many of us associate effort with inferior ability. Think of the fable "The Tortoise and the Hare", which teaches us to put in more effort if we lack the natural abilities. If you have a fixed mindset, you may actually be *afraid* to put in effort since (a) you think the need to work harder means you're not "special" enough, and (b) you're silently worried that your best effort may be inadequate.

KEY QUOTES

"When you're given a positive label, you're afraid of losing it, and when you're hit with a negative label, you're afraid of deserving it."

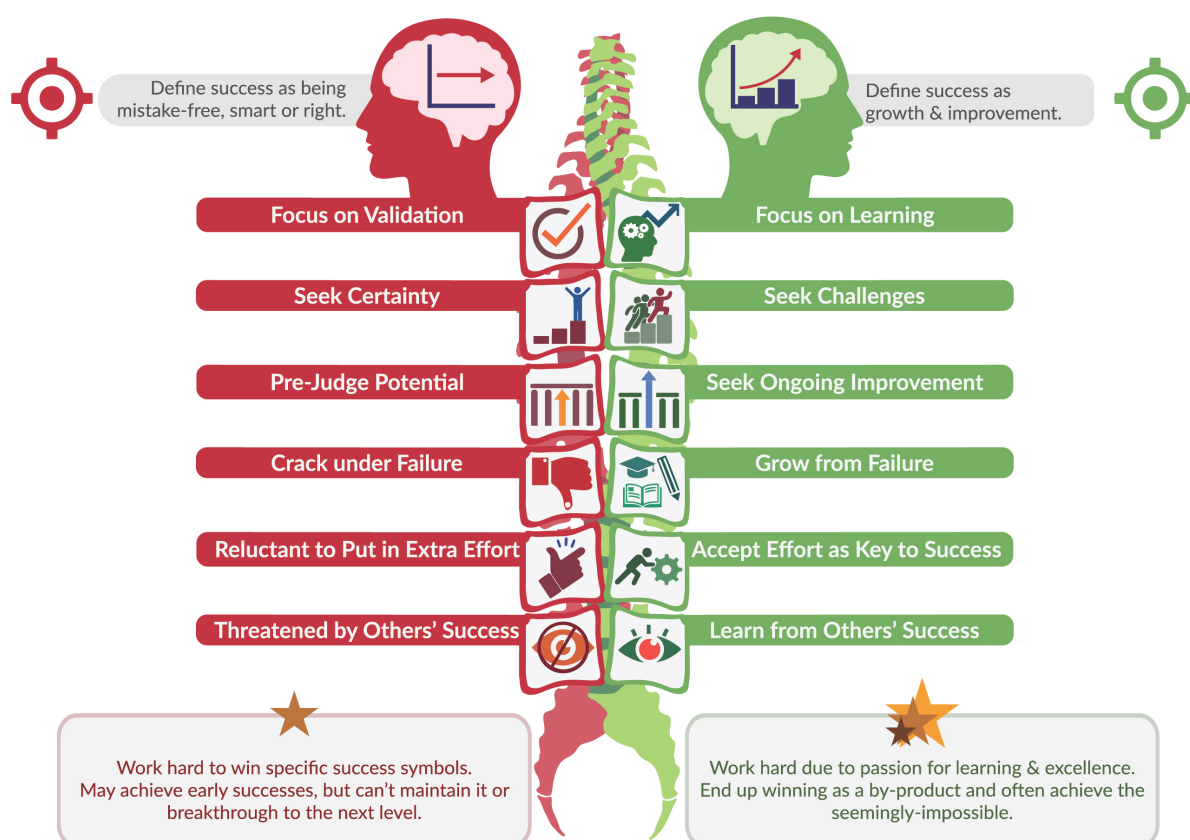
"A growth mindset helps people to see prejudice for what it is—someone else's view of them—and to confront it with their confidence and abilities intact."

"From the point of view of the fixed mindset, effort is only for people with deficiencies."

- Effort is crucial to success, regardless of your level of talent. Most “geniuses” accomplish what they do through years of hard work, e.g. Mozart produced his first famous pieces only after 10 years of practice and composition. Inventions are not a flash of brilliance, but the result of a series of discoveries that make a breakthrough possible.

There’s nothing wrong with the desire to win; the issue is whether winning is a means or an ends. People with a fixed mindset tend to put in hard work only to achieve a specific outcome (e.g. to win an award or get to a certain position). People with a growth mindset are driven by their passion for excellence, and end up winning as a result of their growth.

Here’s a recap of the 2 mindsets:



Mindset in Parenting and Education

Messages about Success

Parents and teachers often praise children with the good intention of motivating them. However, praises are a double-edged sword—they can build confidence or encourage fixed mindsets.

KEY QUOTES

“The lightbulb has become the symbol for that single moment when the brilliant solution strikes, but there was no single moment of invention.”

“Many growth-minded people didn’t even plan to go to the top. They got there as a result of doing what they love.”



As a **rule of thumb**, don't praise for abilities or talents; instead, praise for processes (strategies, effort, and choices).



When children are **praised for their abilities** or given positive labels like "talented", "gifted", or "smart", it cultivates a fixed mindset.

- It creates stress to meet expectations, and they start to doubt themselves if they don't. They may also get the wrong message that they're loved only because of their talent or intelligence.
- Research found that ability-praised students began to avoid challenges that may reveal their flaws, and enjoyed challenges less. After facing setbacks, they performed worse, even when they were given easier problems. In fact, 40% of these students were ashamed of their low scores and lied about them.



A better way is to **praise for effort and approach**.

- Affirm children's love for learning, effort, strategies and tenacity in handling challenges. For example, you can say, "That was such a challenging project. I really admire how you stayed focused and tried creative ways to get it done."
- Students who were praised for their effort were motivated to take on new challenges, and kept learning and improving. They also enjoyed the challenges more.

Messages about Failure



When kids make mistakes, how parents and teachers respond will also shape their mindset and future outcomes.



Avoid giving **negative labels or excuses**.

- Don't attribute failure to abilities e.g., "He's so useless" or "She's just not as smart as her brother".
- Don't protect them from the failure, e.g. blame circumstances, brush off the mistake as unimportant, or assure them they'll win in the future because they're talented or the best.

KEY QUOTES

"Praising children's intelligence harms their motivation and it harms their performance."

"Telling children they're smart, in the end, made them feel dumber and act dumber, but claim they were smarter."

"Having innate talent is not a goal. Expanding skills and knowledge is."



It's better to give constructive feedback so they know how to learn from the failure and improve. For example, you can say, "I loved the effort you've put in for this test. Now, let's figure out the parts that you didn't understand." Reassure the child before a test/performance that you'll be proud of them for their learning and effort, regardless of the outcome.



Harsh judgement and punishments tend to backfire. The worst message you can send to your kids is that they're only loved if they succeed on your terms.

- Children who were punished as babies for crying and fussing tend to become angry with (or even abuse) other children who cry. Those who're punished for disobeying their parents (without explanation) don't learn how to diagnose and solve problems.
- You can say "No" fairly and respectfully, by sharing your decision-making process. Even if the child is clearly not putting in effort, you can express your frustration gently, e.g., "I feel disappointed that you're missing this chance to learn. Shall we see how to do this better in the future?"

Education, Teaching and Coaching



Mindsets affect teachers and coaches, as well as the students and trainees in their charge.



In education, you shouldn't lower standards just to let students score, nor should you raise standards without providing the support for students to reach them.

- Great teachers set high standards and teach students how to achieve the results. They take an interest in all their students, rather than pre-judge them and focus only on the achievers. They make a difference because of their love for learning, and their genuine passion to learn together with their students. They use a growth framework and give process-related feedback.
- Marva Collins successfully transformed many "problematic" students who were discarded by other schools. She believed in the children, took pride and joy in their learning, and gave

KEY QUOTES

"Growth-minded parents... set high standards, but they teach the children how to reach them."

"Don't judge. Teach. It's a learning process."

"Teachers with the fixed mindset know which students to give up on before they've even met them."

"The great teachers believe in the growth of the intellect and talent, and they are fascinated with the process of learning."

"Growth-minded teachers tell students the truth and then give them the tools to close the gap."

them a challenging learning schedule and materials. The children rose to the challenge and were motivated to learn.

- Just because a student seems indifferent doesn't mean he/she doesn't care. Dweck shares an example of a student who refused to cooperate and even ripped up his assignments. Once the teacher showed that she wasn't judging the student, but was genuinely interested in his learning, he started to make a shift.



Parents and teachers can mould children's mindsets, while coaches affect their players' or trainees' mindsets and results. For instance:

- Fixed-mindset basketball coach Bobby Knight only cared about his players' results; when they failed, he was harsh and even shamed them publicly. This worked for some players, but caused others to lose their passion for the sport.
- Growth-mindset coach John Wooden didn't demand his team to be mistake-free or win all the time. Instead, he gave equal respect to all his players, and pushed them to give their best effort each time.

Mindset in Sports



Natural Abilities vs Growth Mindset



In sports, many people associate natural talent with visible physical attributes, when the true differentiator is in the mind. Dweck presents many examples of sportspeople who made it to the top by using the growth-mindset to overcome disadvantages and short-term failures.



Mohammad Ali didn't have the "natural" physique of a boxer, but he made up for it with speed and mental sharpness. Michael Jordan was rejected in college and the first 2 NBA teams he applied for, and became a basketball legend from hard work and self-improvement. These are examples of the growth mindset at work.

KEY QUOTES

"As parents, teachers, and coaches, we are entrusted with people's lives...the growth mindset has a key role to play in helping us fulfill our mission and in helping them fulfill their potential."

*"You may be outscored but you will never lose."
- Coach Wooden*

"As much as our culture talks about individual effort and self-improvement, deep down...we revere the naturals."



On the other hand, tennis player John McEnroe regularly bragged about being #1, and found excuses when he lost. People like him and Billy Beane were successful earlier in their sporting career, but their fixed mindset eventually worked against them.

Character: The Vital Ingredient



Character is essential in sports—it's the ability to dig deep, find your strength and keep going in face of setbacks. It determines if you can make it to the top and stay there. It decides if you crack in face of failure or persevere to make a comeback. Character is built on the growth mindset; Dweck calls it the “mind of a champion”.



You can identify someone's mindset from what they say. Basketballer Iciss Tillis reveals her fixed mindset when she says, “I just feel like I'd be such a failure...and I'm going to end up like my dad: a nobody.” Candace Parker shows her growth-minded thinking when she says, “If you work hard at something, you get out what you put in.”



Attitude toward success: Champions like John Wooden, Tiger Woods, and Mia Hamm care about winning, but they focus on pushing themselves to be the best they can be. They see winning as a by-product of being their personal best, unlike others like McEnroe who see winning as a way to affirm their superiority.



Attitude toward failure: Growth-minded athletes treat setbacks as a wake-up call and an opportunity to learn, like how Michael Jordan kept persevering in face of failure. Fixed minded athletes are poor losers—McEnroe was so humiliated from losing a match that he didn't play mixed doubles for 20 years, and Sergio Garcia fired his caddies and blamed others when he performed badly.



Staying at the top: Those with a growth mindset (e.g. Michael Jordan, Tiger Woods) keep working on themselves, thus continue to perform even as they age.



Star mentality vs team-player. All sports are essentially team sports—even swimmers must be supported by a team of trainers, nutritionists etc. Fixed-minded athletes love the spotlight and being superheroes, while growth-minded

KEY QUOTES

“Just because some people can do something with little or no training, it doesn't mean that others can't do it (and sometimes do it even better) with training.”

“I've missed more than nine thousand shots. I've lost almost three hundred games. Twenty-six times, I've been trusted to take the game-winning shot, and missed.”
- Michael Jordan

“A superstar's talent can win games, but it's teamwork that wins championships.”

athletes understand that being a star-player is really about playing their role well.

Mindset in Business and Leadership



Mindset and Business Management



Growth mindsets can help companies to thrive while fixed mindsets lead to their downfall.



Examples in business. Enron's focus on big talents led to an elitist culture, with a fixed mindset and tendency to deny deficiencies, leading to its demise. On the other hand, Jim Collins found that good companies that became great had a common success factor—they had humble, hardworking leaders who focused on improvement rather than the limelight.



Mindsets affect **management decisions**. In a study, participants were split into 2 groups and tasked to run a simulated company. One group was told that their performance was measured by their capacity (fixed mindset), while the other group was told to develop management skills (growth mindset). Both groups couldn't meet their targets initially. However, the growth mindset team could learn from their mistakes and kept improving, while the fixed mindset team was too bogged down by their fixed abilities to learn.

Mindset and Leadership



Fixed mindset in leadership. Leaders with fixed mindsets (e.g. Lee Iacocca, Albert Dunlap) use their companies as a vehicle to validate themselves.

- Star CEOs with big egos believe they and their companies are superior. They focus more on their image and on displaying their superiority, than on tackling the tough problems in the company.
- The "CEO Disease" can affect leaders at all levels. Due to their desire to be seen as heroes, such leaders focus on short-term strategies that make them look good, surround themselves

KEY QUOTES

"Just about every sport is in some sense a team sport. No one does it alone."

"A company that cannot selfcorrect cannot thrive."

"People who preen their egos and look for the next self-image boost are not the same people who foster long-term corporate health."

"Fixed-mindset leaders... must repeatedly affirm that they are superior, and the company is simply a platform for this."

with worshippers, and lose touch with reality. Fixed-minded leaders also tend to be defensive, controlling, or put others down. As the people around them start to behave the same way, the disease spreads.



Growth mindset in leadership. Growth-minded leaders (e.g. Jack Welch, Lou Gerstner, Ann Mulcahy) focus on growing themselves, their people and their companies.

- They understand the need to address weaknesses for long term success, even if that means getting criticized in the short-term.
- For example, Jack Welch always made time to meet with his front-line employees. He believed in mentoring, focused on teamwork rather than superstars, selected people with the passion for growth and excellence, and removed “brutal bosses”. Although Welch also became overconfident and made mistakes at times, he used these as lessons and wake-up calls.



Growth mindset can be learned:

- Cultivate a growth mindset in your organization by: (a) finding *managers* with a growth mindset, (b) *training* people in mindsets and communication/mentoring skills, and (c) creating a *conducive environment* where people can thrive—through constructive feedback, the belief that skills can be learned, seeing managers as learning resources, and knowing the organization values learning and perseverance.
- Dweck’s “Brainology” workshop helps people to understand how the brain works, how abilities can be developed through coaching and practice, and how they can develop themselves and others.

Mindset in Relationships



Mindset and Love Relationships



At some point in our lives, all of us are hurt by others. Our mindset determines if we can deal with heartaches and disappointments, or

KEY QUOTES

“Jack Welch was not a perfect person, but he was devoted to growth. This devotion kept his ego in check, kept him connected to reality, and kept him in touch with his humanity.”

“The lesson is: Create an organization that prizes the development of ability—and watch the leaders emerge.”

stay permanently scarred. This is because **our mindset determines our beliefs about (a) our qualities, (b) our partner's qualities, and (c) the relationship's qualities.**



People with **fixed mindsets in relationships** believe that they, their partners and the relationship cannot change. Thus, they:

- Assume that if they're meant to be together, they'll understand each other and agree on everything. When things go wrong, they get disillusioned that things will never improve;
- Give themselves labels like "unloveable", "unworthy". When things go wrong, they feel judged or rejected, lash out or blame themselves/their partners, rather than seek understanding and solutions; and
- Tend to compare and compete with their partners to see who's smarter, more popular etc.



People with **growth mindsets in relationships** believe that they, their partners and the relationship can change. Thus, they:

- Focus on the issues, choose growth and understanding, and learn from bad experiences, so they can improve the relationship; and
- Understand the importance of putting in effort, learning to communicate and work through differences.

Mindset and Other Relationships



Friendship. People with fixed mindsets may unintentionally use their friends for validation and to offload their issues. They are usually ready to offer advice for their friends' problems, but are less interested if their friends are doing well. If others don't feel good or validated around you, problems will emerge in the relationship.



Shyness can be found in people with fixed or growth mindsets. However, studies found that those with fixed mindsets tend to remain socially-impaired, while those with growth mindset

KEY QUOTES

"Mind reading instead of communicating inevitably backfires."

"There are no problem-free candidates. The trick is to acknowledge each other's limitations, and build from there."

"Ego-wise, it's easy to be sympathetic to someone in need. It's your assets and your successes that are problems for people who derive their self-esteem from being superior."

"The belief that partners have the potential for change should not be confused with the belief that the partner will change."

are more likely to overcome their shyness by learning new social skills.



Social-emotional skills can be learned. Most relationship issues stem from communication problems rather than character flaws. For things to change, there must be motivation and commitment to take concrete actions. This starts with a willingness to focus on what the other party wants, so they feel you're trying to help them to reach their goals (rather than change them into what *you* want).

Changing Mindsets



In the book, Dweck shares many stories to show that mindsets can be learned and changed. However, **the key message is not that fixed mindsets are bad and growth mindsets are good; it's about creating awareness of the 2 mindsets and their impact, so you can make a conscious choice.** Having a growth-mindset doesn't mean that you must change everything or seek perfection. It's about accepting where you are—with your imperfections—and removing artificial constraints so you can decide if/what changes to make in your best interest.

Getting Started



If you decide to make the shift, here are some steps and tips that you can use to get started:



Be aware of your mindset(s): Use this [questionnaire](#) to identify which mindset you're skewed toward. Do you have a different mindset toward different aspects of your abilities or personal qualities?



Reflect on the impact of fixed vs growth mindsets:

- Think of people who have growth vs fixed mindsets. Do they try to grow/challenge themselves, or prove/defend themselves. Why and how do they do that?
- Research on someone you admire—you're likely to discover how much work they've put in to achieve what they did.

KEY QUOTES

"The growth mindset is a starting point for change, but people need to decide for themselves where their efforts toward change would be most valuable."

- Imagine facing a big challenge where your success/failure is visible to all. How will you feel and act with a fixed mindset vs a growth mindset?



Know that you can choose and change your mindset.

- List down what you use to judge yourself (e.g. test results, what people say). Examine them and realize they don't really dictate your outcomes.
- When you're feeling discouraged by a challenge or setback, take action despite bad feelings. Focus on what you can learn or do to overcome it. Make a concrete plan, and visualize in vivid detail when, where, and how you'll carry out your plan. Imagine your brain forging new connections as you do so.
- Instead of saying "I can't do that", say "I can't do that yet", and make it happen.



Examine your mindsets in various aspects of your life: as a parent, teacher, coach, at the workplace and in your relationships. Consider how you can shift your mindset and nurture growth mindsets in the people around you.

Other Details in the Book to Look out For



The book includes many other anecdotes, examples, and resources such as:

- Examples and studies in schools, sports, and companies;
- Letters from readers on how the book and ideas have helped them;
- Tips at the end of each chapter to help you apply or reflect upon the ideas in the book; and
- Detailed scenarios of setbacks that you may encounter, with a walkthrough of the thoughts and emotions you may experience with a fixed mindset, and how to shift to a growth mindset.

For more details and resources, do visit <https://mindsetonline.com>.

KEY QUOTES

"My work has been about growth, and it has helped foster my own growth. It is my wish that it will do the same for you."